Teach Reality, Not Rhetoric

By Rod Rose

Cho Seung-Hui carried at least 17 magazines for the Glock 19 he used to kill 32 people, and then himself, at Virginia Tech.

Witnesses said he took up to a minute to change magazines.

A rational human being who has chosen to use defend himself with a firearm can be trained to draw and fire two aimed rounds into a target the size of a paper plate 21 feet away in less than 2 seconds.

Do the math.

Ignoring the math — pretending that "gun-free zones" are valid logical defenses against madmen, instead of insane denials of reality — dooms us to hearing about another Cho Seung-Hui. There will be another public massacre, in a school, Amish or public, in a shopping mall, at a fast-food restaurant.

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There will be more slaughters unless and until this society admits that evil exists; that irrational individuals walk the streets; that the world is not and never will be perfect.

INTRODUCTION

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No guarantees are expressed or implied when we are born. Legislate away, pontificate, twist the facts like rifling in a barrel — we are all going to die, but we can improve the odds we will live longer.

As a human being you are obligated to be aware of your surroundings. "Fend for yourself" is the advertising slogan of knife and tool maker Gerber. Having that ability allows you to fend for others.

The Founding Fathers intended that we inherit a civil society. For many reasons — sociological, political, economic, demographic, theological — we've lost it. It's time for us to take it back.

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Knives and firearms are nothing more than tools. They are not, of and in themselves, dangerous. It is only when they are misused that they maim and kill.

Some newspapers, some commentators, some editorial cartoonists, have criticized "the media" — even though they are part of "the media" — for "exploiting" the massacre at Virginia Tech. That they are exploiting the tragedy for their own purposes is, of course, irrelevant.

NBC has been harshly criticized for airing some of Cho Seung-Hui's incoherent ranting. It serves no purpose, critics say.

Cho offers a lesson if we have the wisdom to recognize the opportunity. Authorities have responsibilities; if they failed in their obligations, the public has both the right and the duty to see that corrections are made and, if appropriate, punishments are administered.

"Let's not play the blame game," is another senseless but common reaction.

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Why not? The police knew, in 2005, that Cho was a potential threat; a VT professor told NBC's Matt Lauer she had expressed her concerns to police. They offered to place an officer outside the classroom, but that was legally as far as they could go. Cho had not made a direct threat; without that threat, the police had no authority to do more.

It's never too early, although it can be too late, to begin assigning blame. Solutions can't be proposed if the problem is ignored.

If the two police departments have a communications gap, build a bridge.

If the mental health professionals who could have helped Cho but could not because of inadequate funding, then give them more money. If they lack other resources, provide them.

Insisting that the lowest bid is appropriate for every aspect of civilization is reckless, irresponsible, cheap in the derogatory sense, and ultimately suicidal for a rational society.

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"If lower taxes are your priority over human life, then we know what sort of person you are," Garrison Keilor said.

This is a violent society. It's violent because violence makes money. It's violent because parents have surrendered their obligations. It's violent because we are under enormous stress.

And it can be made less violent. It can be healed. But do Americans have the courage and intelligence to accept that cures are sometimes painful?

Until we stop pretending otherwise, there are more Columbines, Virginia Techs and San Ysidro McDonalds in our future.

We have to teach our children — and ourselves — the skills to recognize threats, and the appropriate responses. Sometimes it's as simple as crossing the street. Sometimes it means running as fast and as hard as we can. Sometimes it means killing someone, then facing the consequences of having assumed the horrendous responsibility of choosing to carry a deadly weapon.

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That's reality. When you send your children to school, do so after having given them the skills to recognize threats. They must know when slipping quietly out of sight is the best choice.

They must also know when they have only two choices: Defending themselves or becoming a corpse.

Sheeple or sheepdog. It's your choice.

NOTE: ***Sheeple*** *is a term of disparagement, a portmanteau created by combining the words "sheep" and "people"; a reference to herd mentality. It is often used to denote persons who acquiesce to authority, and thus undermine their own human individuality. The implication of sheeple is that as a collective, people believe whatever they are told, without processing it to be sure that it is an accurate representation of the real world around them. The term is generally used in a political or religious sense.*

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